My Little Music Grammar

LEVEL 1



I learn to read and write music

MUSIC MOTION

My Little Music Grammar · Level 1
I learn to read and write music
Pupil's workbook for the *Music in the Classroom* programme

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CANELO SAYS

Each chapter takes up two pages, facing each other. Open the workbook and look at both at once!

For teachers and families

A few words before we begin

At school, every child learns to read and write words. Music is different: almost all of us listen to it our whole lives without being able to read it. This workbook would like to help change that.

My Little Music Grammar goes with the **Music in the Classroom** programme by Music Motion. Each chapter follows a Level 1 lesson: what the child learns, a game to do in the workbook and a game to play at home, ten minutes a week. You don't need to know any music to join in: playing together is enough.

Music never comes on its own. In these pages you will find history (a song carved in stone almost two thousand years ago), poetry (Edward Lear), mathematics (note values are fractions and a bar is a sum) and geometry. Learning to read music is also a way of looking at the world. Several of the fun facts come from the author's book, *When Sound Becomes Music*.

You don't need to buy an instrument: at **musicmotionsuite.com** the computer keyboard becomes one, tuned by ear.

A tip: free, easy-to-follow lessons on using the programs step by step are at **musicmotionsuite.com/suite/ejercicios/**.



CANELO

I'm Canelo, and I'll be with you all the way through the workbook. When you see me, it means I have something to tell you. Woof!

How each chapter works

- **The story**: the new idea, told with a picture.
- **Let's play!**: activities to do in the workbook with a pencil, and some games on the computer.
- **Canelo says**: a tip from Canelo to help you understand or remember.
- **Did you know...?**: a fun fact for those who want to know more.
- **At home**: a ten-minute game with the family.

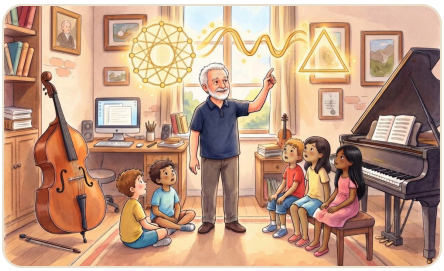
The friends in this book

They lived in different times and places, but they all have something to do with music.



Canelo

The little dog of the tune machine. He goes with you all the way through the workbook.



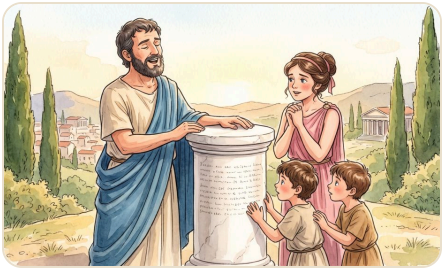
Mr Mario

Double bassist. He has played in orchestras for many years and loves showing that music is full of numbers and shapes.



Pythagoras

A wise man from Greece. With a single string he discovered that sounds which sound good together can be counted.



Seikilos

Almost two thousand years ago he had a song carved on a little stone column. You can still sing it today!



Edward Lear

An English poet and painter. More than a hundred and fifty years ago he wrote funny poems that sound like music: in one, an owl sings to a small guitar.



Wolfgang and his dad Leopold

Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart learnt music from his dad, who was a violinist and a teacher. Later on we will play a dice game with them.



The cat and the fiddle

From the old nursery rhyme 'Hey Diddle Diddle'. A cow jumps over the moon and a dish runs away with a spoon!



The reed musicians

Thousands of years ago, by blowing into reeds, they discovered the same thing as Pythagoras.



Your classmates

With them you will sing, compose and present your own tune.

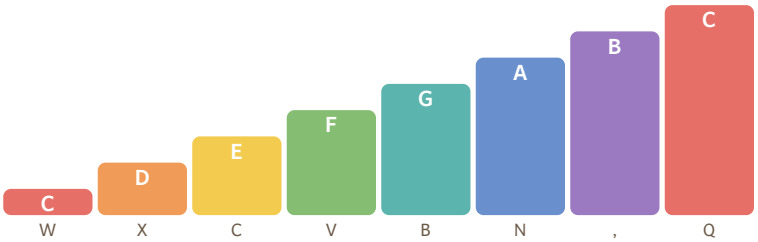
CHAPTER 1

The singing staircase

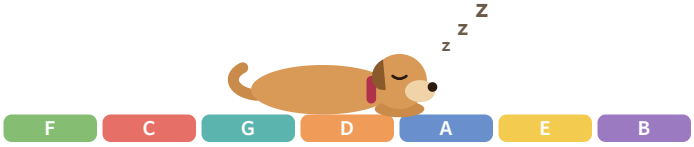
Listening and singing



Sounds can go up and down too, like a staircase. Each step is a note and has a name: **C, D, E, F, G, A, B**... and then **C** again, higher up. (In some countries these notes are called Do, Re, Mi, Fa, Sol, La, Si.) Walk up it singing, with even steps, like a clock: that is the **beat**.



The singing staircase. On the computer keyboard: Z X C V B N M, and A for the high C.



Canelo's mat: each colour is a fifth higher. ***They are the seven notes of the staircase!***

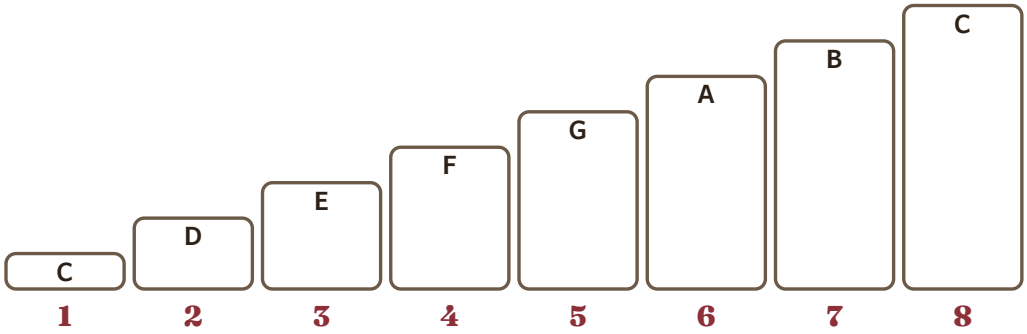


CANELO SAYS

Draw the tune in the air: when the music goes up, raise your hand; when it goes down, lower it. That way you can see the music with your body!

Let's play!

1. Read the name of each step, find it on Canelo's mat on the opposite page and colour the step in its colour.



Computer keyboard: Z X C V B N M, and A for the high C.

2. Write the names of the missing notes:

C	D		F		A		C
	D		F		A		C
		E		G		B	

At home

- **The echo**: open the keyboard at **musicmotionsuite.com/apps/mmk-demo.html**. One of you plays a key between Z and M; the other sings it back. Then swap.
- **The tuner**: sing a long note to the tuner and see which name appears.
- **The beat in the kitchen**: put on a recording from the keyboard (the RECORDINGS list) and tap the beat together: with your hands, your feet or a wooden spoon on a saucepan. Can you keep going together right to the end?
- **The tune machine**: Canelo's own. Open **musicmotionsuite.com/suite/tragamonedas.html**, press SPIN and then PLAY. Every spin is a new tune. Which one do you like best?

CHAPTER 2

High and low, long and short

High and low · long and short



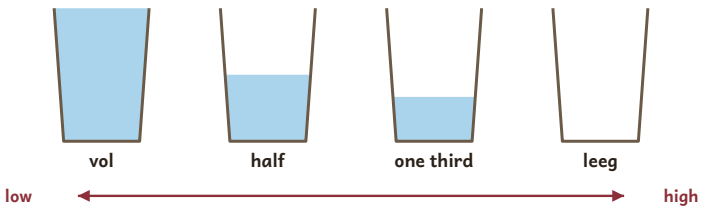
Pythagoras of Samos (6th century BC) with the monochord.

'Turn the music down,' they say at home: that is about the volume. In music, **high** and **low** mean something different: whether a sound is **thin** or **deep**.

A **high** sound is thin and bright, like the song of a bird or a whistle. A **low** sound is thick and deep, like thunder, a big drum or Mr Mario's double bass.

Centuries ago, **Pythagoras** discovered it with a single string: the shorter the part that vibrates, the higher it sounds.

Big things sound low; small things sound high. The elephant and the lion have low voices; the mouse and the little bird have high ones. The big double bass sounds low; the small violin sounds high. Glasses of water work the same way: the more water, the lower the sound.



Tap each glass gently with a spoon: the full one sounds lower, the empty one higher.

Music has a heart that beats. That heartbeat is called the **beat**: always the same distance apart, like the tick-tock of a clock or your steps when you walk. When you clap along to a song, you are clapping the beat.

A sound can also be **long** or **short**. We measure that with the beat: a short sound lasts one beat, 'ta'; a long sound lasts several, 'taaaa'.

Let's play!

1. Match each sound to the right word:

a little bird	**high**
thunder	
a whistle	**low**
a big drum	

2. **Up or down?** Open **musicmotionsuite.com/suite/tragamonedas.html#sube**. You will hear two notes: does the second one go up or down? Play ten rounds and write down your score: _____ out of 10.

Did you know...? The metronome marks the beat with a light and a sound. At 60, it gives one beat every second, like the second hand of a clock.

At home

- **Up or down?** The grown-up plays two keys, one after the other. The child shows with a hand whether the sound went up or down.
- **Ta and taaaa**: the child plays one key short and one key long; the grown-up says which was which.
- **The dog's walk**: open **musicmotionsuite.com/suite/tragamonedas.html#paseo**. Canelo walks to the beat of the tune: tap TAP HERE (or the space bar) at every step, together with the beat light. Don't let him trip! Take turns: first the child, then the grown-up.
- **The singing glasses**: fill a few identical glasses with different amounts of water and tap them gently with a spoon. Which glass sounds highest: the one with more water or the one with less?



CANELO SAYS

When I'm happy I bark high, and when I don't like something I growl low. And when I go for a walk, my paws keep the beat!

The sounds of the reed

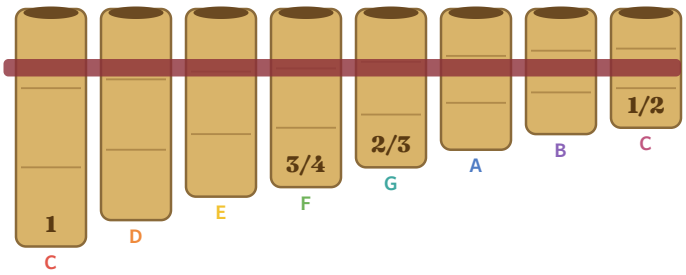
The same note, but higher: a discovery made by all humankind



Pythagoras was not the only one. In many places around the world, people discovered the same thing by listening.

Thousands of years ago, long before there were written scores, people listened carefully to the sounds of nature: the wind in the reeds, the water, the birds. We know little about that music, because nobody wrote it down, but their **instruments** are still here. They cut reeds and blew into them: that is how flutes made of a single reed were born, like the **quena**, and flutes made of many reeds of different lengths, like the **pan pipes (zampoña)**.

By listening, they discovered that a **short** reed sounds **high** and a **long** reed sounds **low**. And that a reed **half** the length sings the same note, but higher. Just like Pythagoras' string!



Pan pipes: the half-length reed (1/2) sings the same note, higher.



CANELO SAYS

Nobody learnt it from anybody else: in Greece, in China and in the Andes, people discovered it by listening. Music belongs to everyone!

MAKE IT!

Your drinking-straw pan pipes

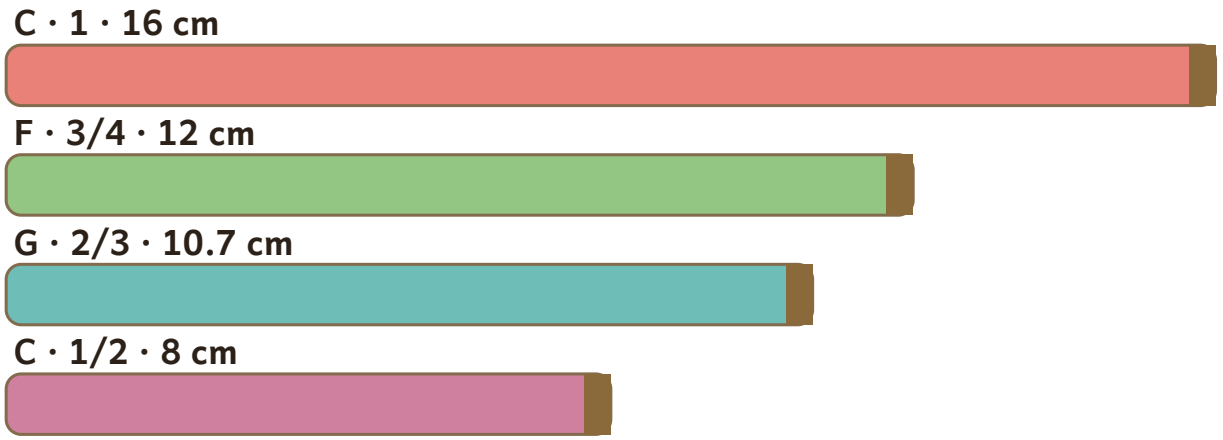
Pythagoras' fractions, in your hands

With four drinking straws you can build your own pan pipes and hear with your own ears what Pythagoras and the reed musicians discovered. The Greeks called them the **syrinx**. A legend tells that the nymph Syrinx turned into a bed of reeds to escape from the god Pan. Pan cut the reeds, tied them in a row and blew: that is why they are called **pan pipes**.

You will need

4 thick drinking straws · scissors · sticky tape · a little modelling clay (Plasticine) · a grown-up to help you cut

1. Lay each straw on the drawing below, which is **actual size**, mark the length and cut it (with a grown-up's help).
2. Seal the bottom end of each straw with a little modelling clay.
3. Tape them together in a row with sticky tape, from the longest to the shortest, with the open ends level at the top.
4. Blow gently across the top, slightly from the side, as when you make a bottle sing.



Actual size. The whole straw (1) gives C; the half straw (1/2) gives the same C, higher.



CANELO SAYS

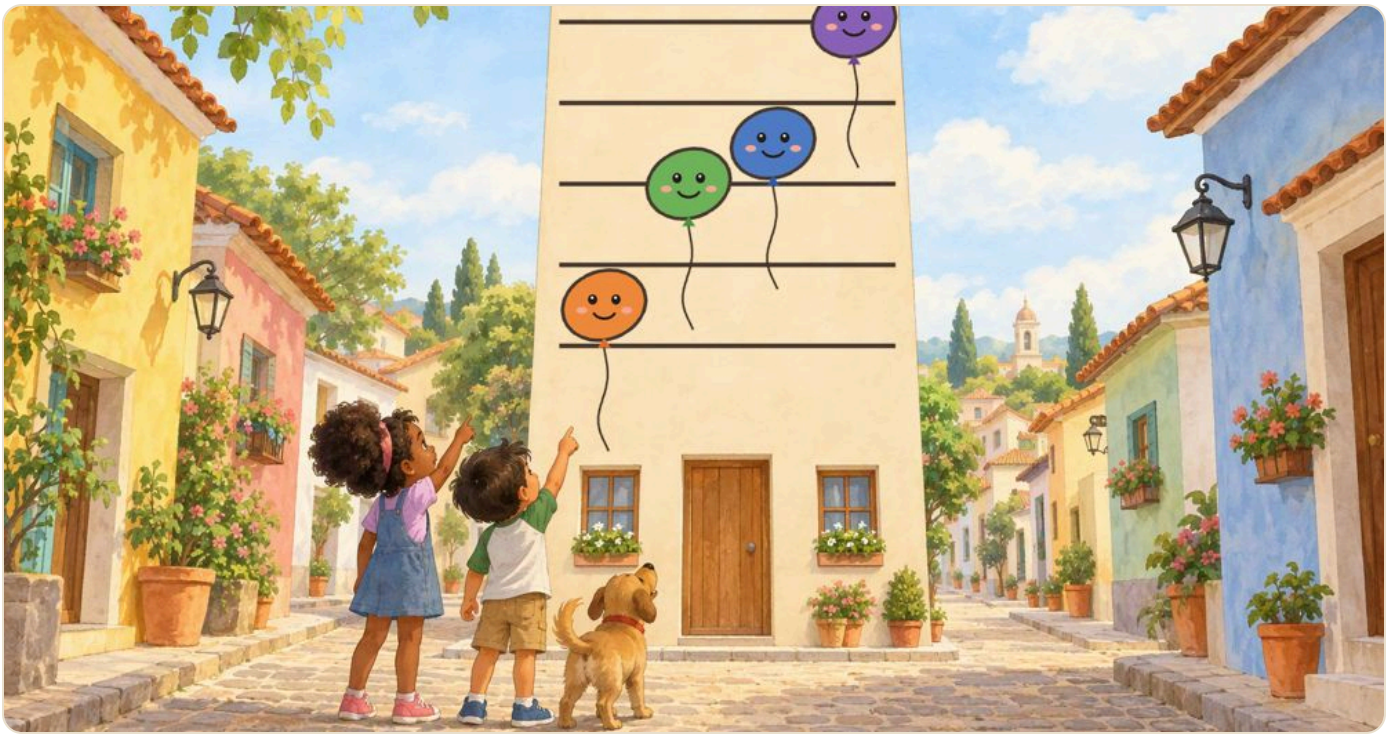
Can you hear it? From low C to F, to G and to high C. You have played Pythagoras' staircase!

Did you know...? A 16 cm straw, closed at the bottom, sounds almost exactly like a C. If yours sounds a little too low, trim it carefully, a tiny bit at a time: that is how pan pipe makers tune their pipes.

CHAPTER 3

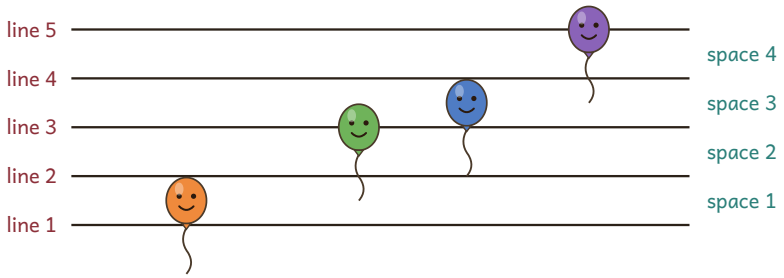
The house of the notes

The stave



So that music is drawn the same way everywhere, the notes live in a house with **five floors**: the **stave**. It has five equal lines, with **four spaces** between them.

Lines and spaces are counted **from the bottom up**: line 1 is the bottom one and line 5 is the top one.



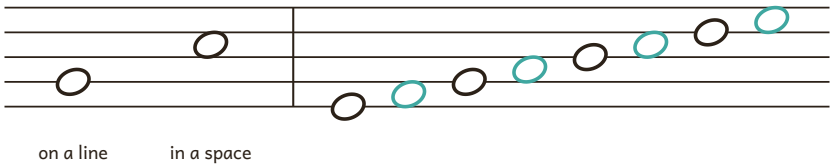
A note can live **on a line**, if the line runs through its middle, or **in a space**, if it sits between two lines without either line touching it. The higher it lives, the higher it sounds.



CANELO SAYS

If the line runs through the note, cross your arms. If the note sits between two lines, press your hands together: it is squeezed between two walls!

This is how they look on the stave: first a note on a line and one in a space; then the singing staircase, which climbs up through the house floor by floor.

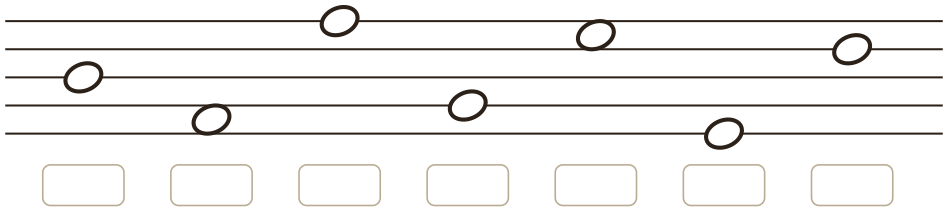


A note on a line and one in a space. Then the staircase: line, space, line, space...

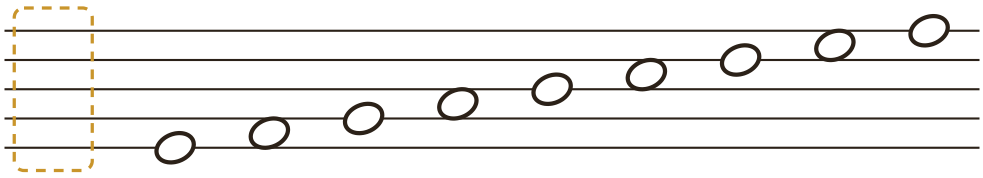
Did you know...? About a thousand years ago, monks wrote music on **four** lines so that they would not forget it. To know which note was which, they put a letter next to one of the lines: the letter **C**, and we still call that note C today. That letter was the first **clef**. Later the fifth line was added, and so our house with five floors was born.

Let's play!

1. Where does each note live? Write **L** (line) or **S** (space), and the number.



2. **Make a C clef:** choose a line and write a **C** in the box at the start: from now on, that line is **C**. Colour the note that lives on it red. Then colour the notes going up in the colours of Canelo's mat: D orange, E yellow, F green...



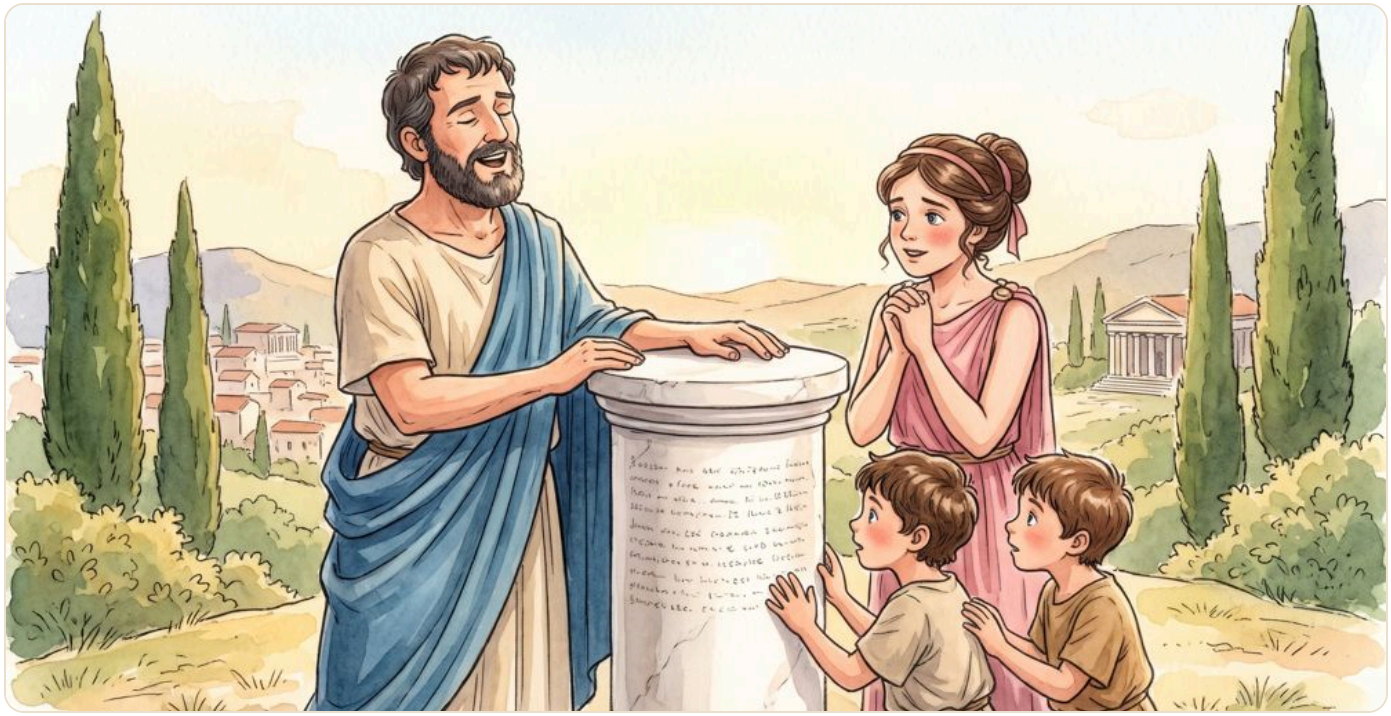
At home

- **The house on the floor**: lay five ropes or ribbons on the floor, each one a step apart. One person says 'line 2' or 'space 3', and the other jumps there. Line 1 is the one closest to you.

CHAPTER 4

The treble clef

The key to the house and the names of the notes



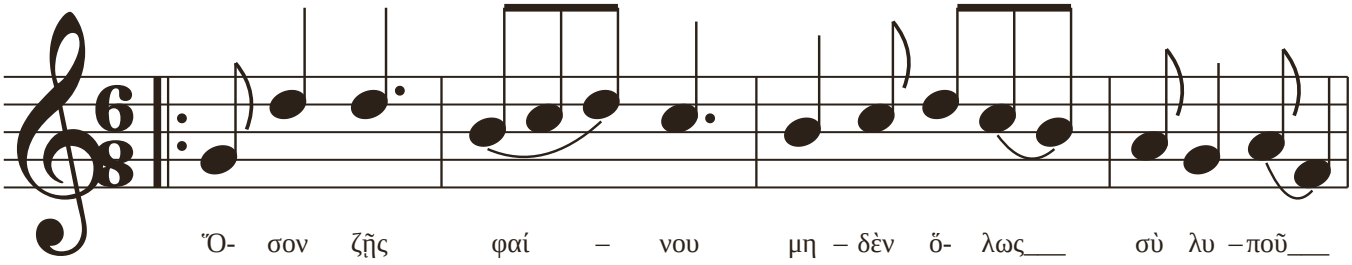
The song of the stone. Almost two thousand years ago, in a Greek town that is now in Turkey, a man called **Seikilos** had a song carved into a small marble column. Above each syllable he put a letter that told you which note to sing. Would you like to hear it? Open **musicmotionsuite.com/suite/seikilos-ninos.html**, click **Start →** and then **Next →** until you reach the page 'Listen to it!'; there, click **▶ Listen**.

The song says: 'While you live, shine; let nothing trouble you.' It is the oldest complete song we know, and we can still sing it because someone knew how to read those letters. That is what you are going to learn now: to read music.



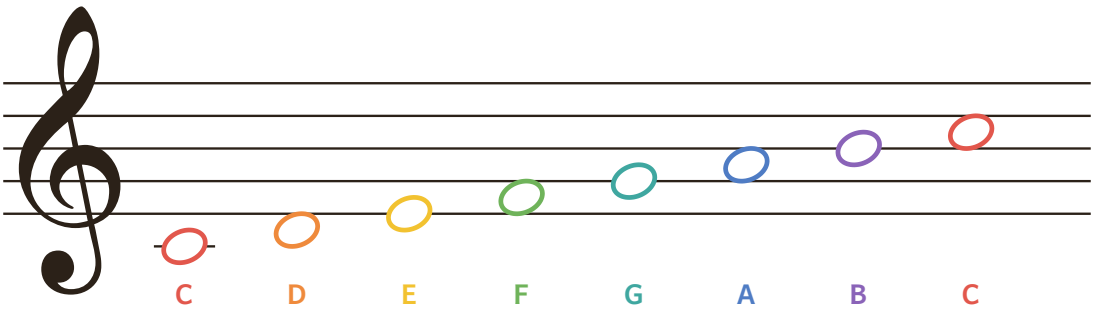
CANELO SAYS

For almost two thousand years the song stood there, silent, waiting for someone who could read it. Just like a book in a library!



Now you can read Seikilos' song in the Score: each Greek syllable sits under its note.

At the start of the stave there is a **clef**. The best known is the **treble clef**: its curl winds around **line 2** and gives that line the name **G**. It grew out of the letter **G**, just like the monks' C, and over the centuries it turned into a curl; that is why it is also called the G clef. It is the key to the house: from that G you know what all the other notes are called. One step higher is A; one step lower is F.

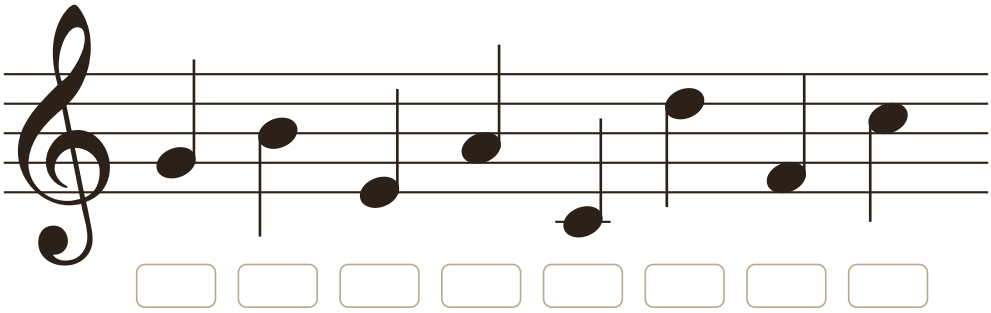


The staircase in the treble clef. The first C needs its own short ledger line, below the stave.
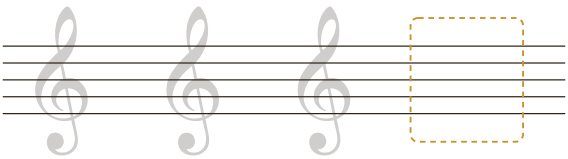
Did you know...? On the lines live **E, G, B, D, F** (from the bottom up) and in the spaces **F, A, C, E**. Look: the spaces spell FACE! Make up a sentence with your class to help you remember the lines.

Let's play!

1. Write the name of each note underneath it.



2. Trace over the grey clefs, starting from line 2, and draw one yourself in the last space.



At home

- **G and its neighbours**: lay the five ropes or ribbons on the floor; the child stands on line 2: 'G lives here.' The grown-up says 'A' or 'F', and the child jumps one step up or down.

CHAPTER 5

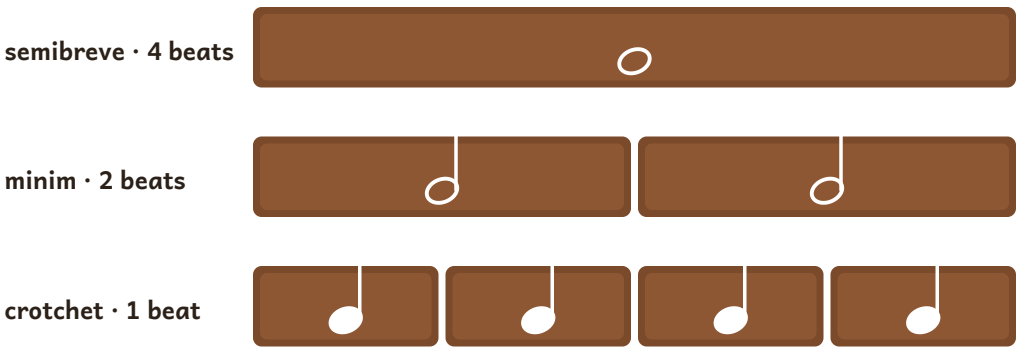
How long does a sound last?

Semibreve, minim and crotchet



How long or short a sound is, you write with the **shape of the note**. To understand it, think of a **bar of chocolate**.

The **semibreve** is the whole bar of chocolate: it lasts **4 beats**. Break it in two, and each half is a **minim**: **2 beats**. Break it into four, and each piece is a **crotchet**: **1 beat**.



The same bar of chocolate, broken into 1, 2 and 4: it is always the same chocolate.

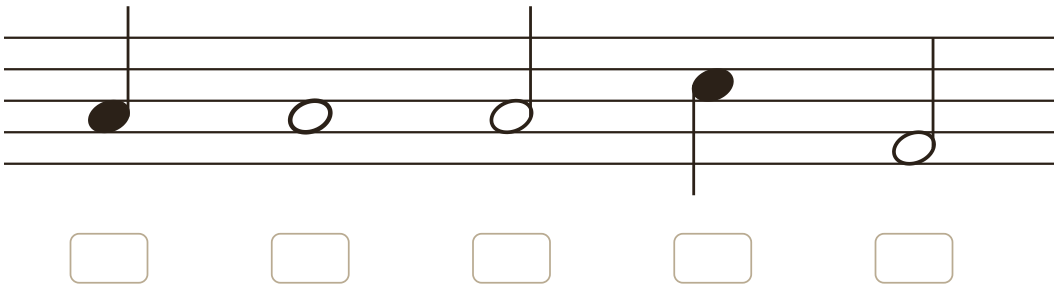


CANELO SAYS

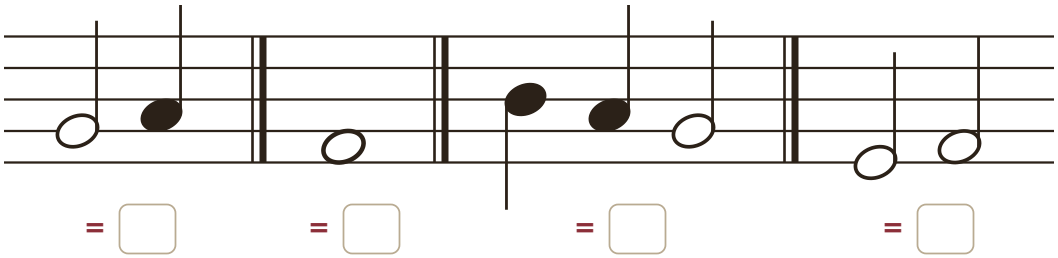
The crotchet lasts as long as one beat, one tick of the clock. It measures everything else! If I eat the whole bar of chocolate, I have eaten a semibreve; if I eat one little piece, only a crotchet. Woof!

Let's play!

1. How many beats does each note value last?



2. Fill in: a semibreve is worth the same as _____ minims, or _____ crotchets.
3. Add up the beats in each group and write the total in the box.



4. Draw a bar of chocolate and break it however you like. Which note values did you get?

At home

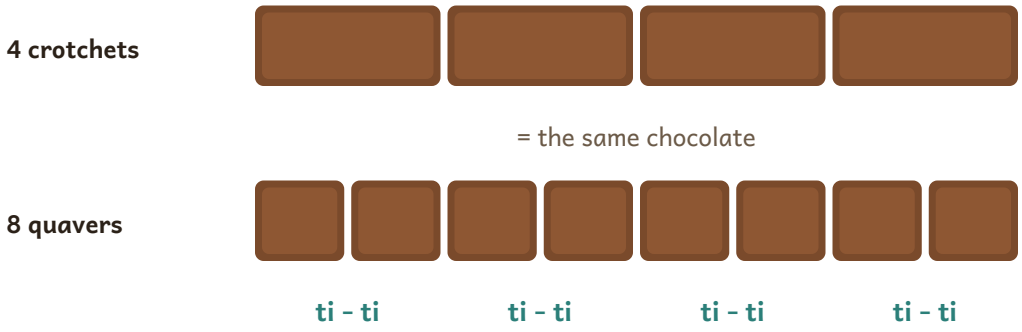
- **Walking the note values**: one person claps a steady beat and says 'crotchet', 'minim' or 'semibreve'. The other takes a step and waits: nothing for the crotchet, one clap for the minim, three for the semibreve.
- **Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star**: sing 'Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star' and open your arms wide on the long note at the end of each line: it is a minim, it lasts two beats.

CHAPTER 6

Quavers and rests

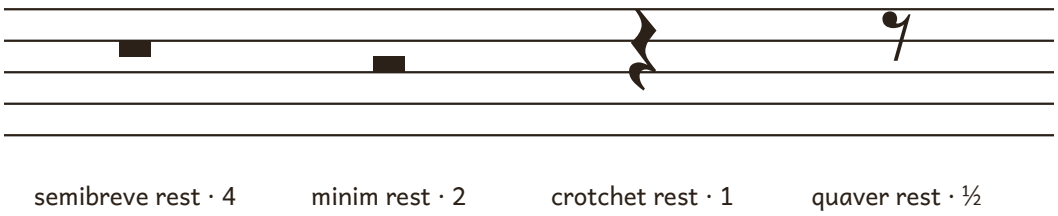
The ‘ti-ti’ and the rest you count

If you split the crotchet in two again, you get **quavers**: two to each beat. You say **‘ti-ti’**. When they come in pairs, they are joined by a **beam**.

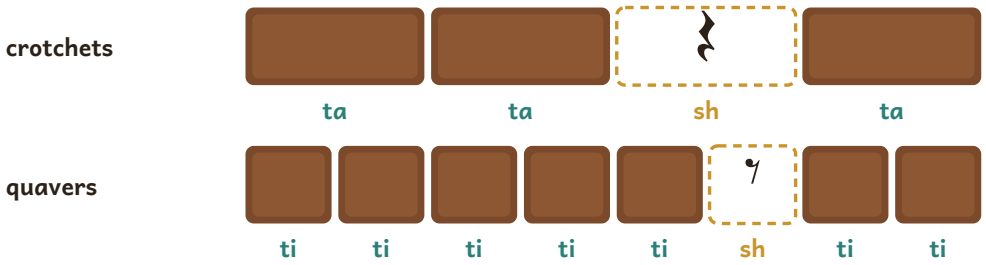


Four crotchets or eight quavers: the same bar of chocolate.

When the music goes quiet, the **rests** come alive. They are an essential part of music: the beat keeps going, even when nothing sounds. Every note value has its own rest, which lasts just as long.



The semibreve rest, the minim rest, the crotchet rest and the quaver rest.
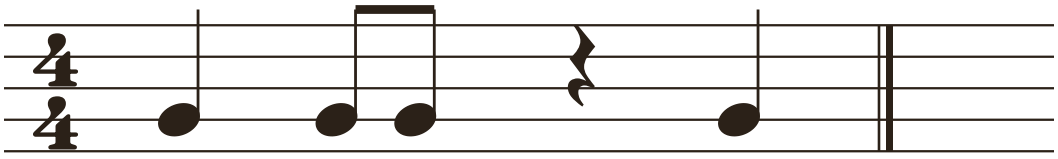


Where a piece of chocolate is missing, there is a rest: the beat goes on, but you cannot hear it.

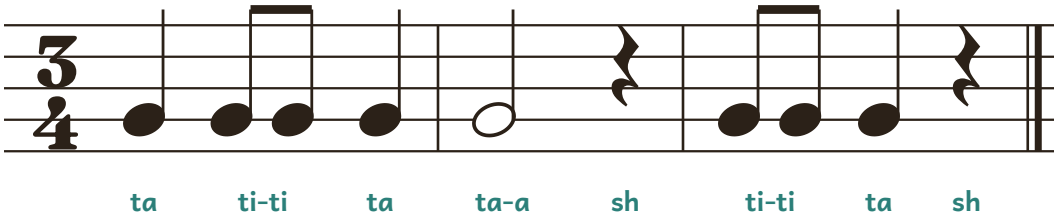
Did you know…? The semibreve rest **hangs** from line 4 (it is heavier, it lasts longer) and the minim rest **sits** on line 3, like a hat.

Let's play!

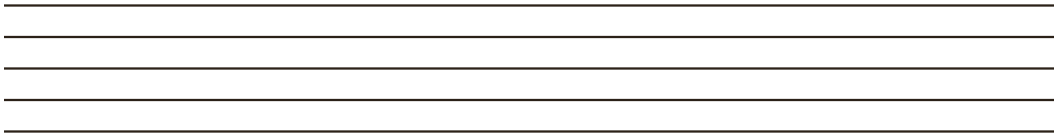
1. Find words that sound like **'ta'** (fish, tree, sun) and words that sound like **'ti-ti'** (table, apple, kitten):
   ta: _____ ti-ti: _____
2. Read this rhythm, saying 'ta', 'ti-ti' and 'sh' for the rest. At the rest, move your hands apart without a sound, as if you were opening a door: the beat keeps going. Then play it on one key.



3. Now a rhythm of **three beats** (3/4), like a waltz or a bambuco from Colombia. Read it, counting 'one, two, three', and clap loudly on 'one'.



4. Make up your own rhythm of four beats, with a rest, and write it here:





CANELO SAYS

At a rest I stand as still as a statue... but inside I keep counting. One, two, three, four!

At home

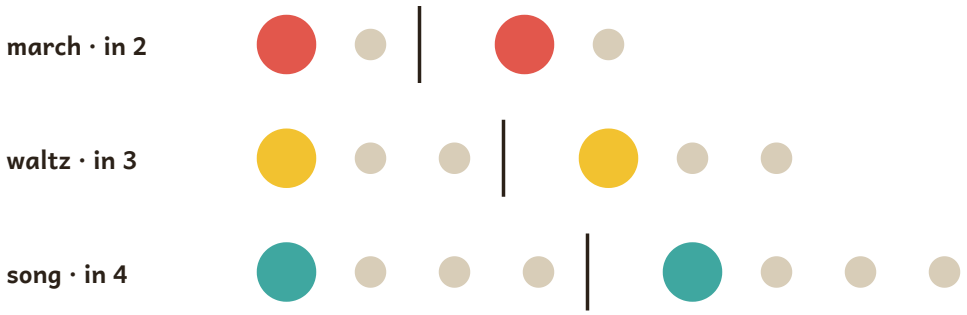
- **Walk the rhythm**: one of you claps the beat and says 'ta', 'ti-ti' or 'sh'. The other takes one step for 'ta', two quick little steps for 'ti-ti' and stands still for 'sh'.

CHAPTER 7

The bar

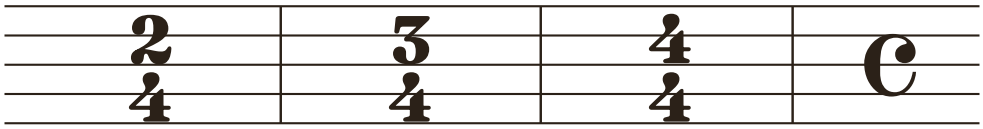
The march, the waltz, the song and the two numbers

When you walk, dance or sing, not all the beats weigh the same: the first one of each group is **stronger**. A group of beats like this is called *a* **bar**, *and in the score a* **bar line** separates the bars. At the end of the piece there is *a* **double bar line**.

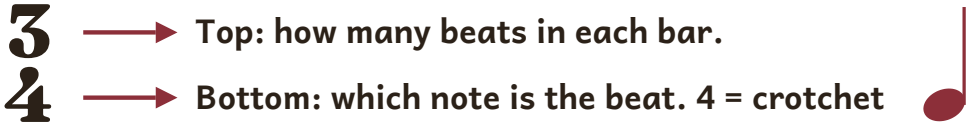


The big circle is the strong beat, the 'one' of every bar.

The time signature is written with **two numbers**, one above the other. The number **on top** tells you how many beats there are in each bar. The number **underneath** tells you which note value is the beat: *a* **4** means the **crotchet**, *a* quarter of the chocolate bar.



2/4, 3/4 and 4/4. 4/4 is so common that it has its own short sign: a big C.



In 3/4 three crotchets fit in each bar: one, two, three.

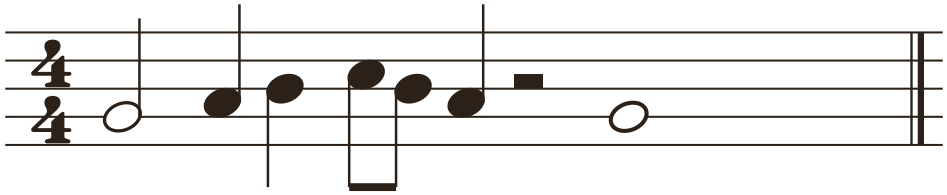


CANELO SAYS

In *a* march my paws say 'one-two, one-two'. In *a* waltz, 'one-two-three, one-two-three!' And you – how do you walk?

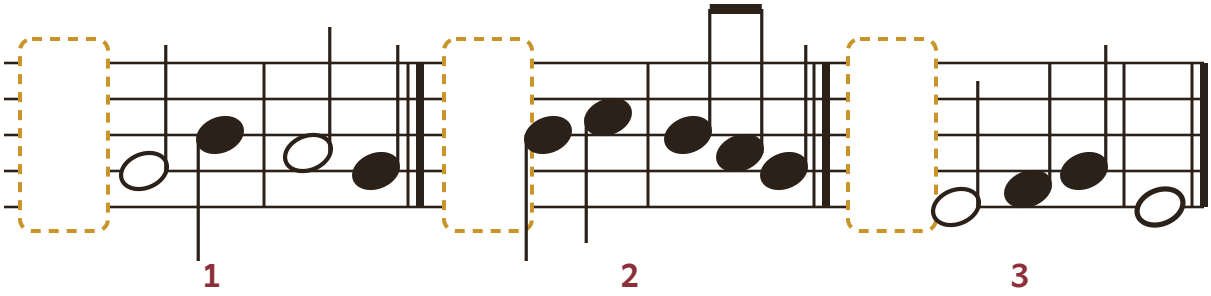
Let's play!

1. This rhythm is in 4/4, but somebody forgot the bar lines. Put them in yourself: each bar must add up to 4 beats.



2. March, waltz or song? Listen to three songs and tap the strong beat (a pasillo or a bambuco from Colombia is also counted in 3).
   Song 1: _____ · you count in ____
   Song 2: _____ · you count in ____
   Song 3: _____ · you count in ____

3. In these three rhythms the time signature has been rubbed out. Count the beats in each bar and write the two numbers in the box.



4. Match each song to its time:

'Happy Birthday' •	• 2/4
'Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star' •	• 3/4
A march •	• 4/4

5. **Dance the bars:** with the march, a firm step on every 'one'; with the waltz, the pasillo or the bambuco, a turn on the 'one' and two soft little steps. Count the bars out loud: in bar 8, finish with a pose!

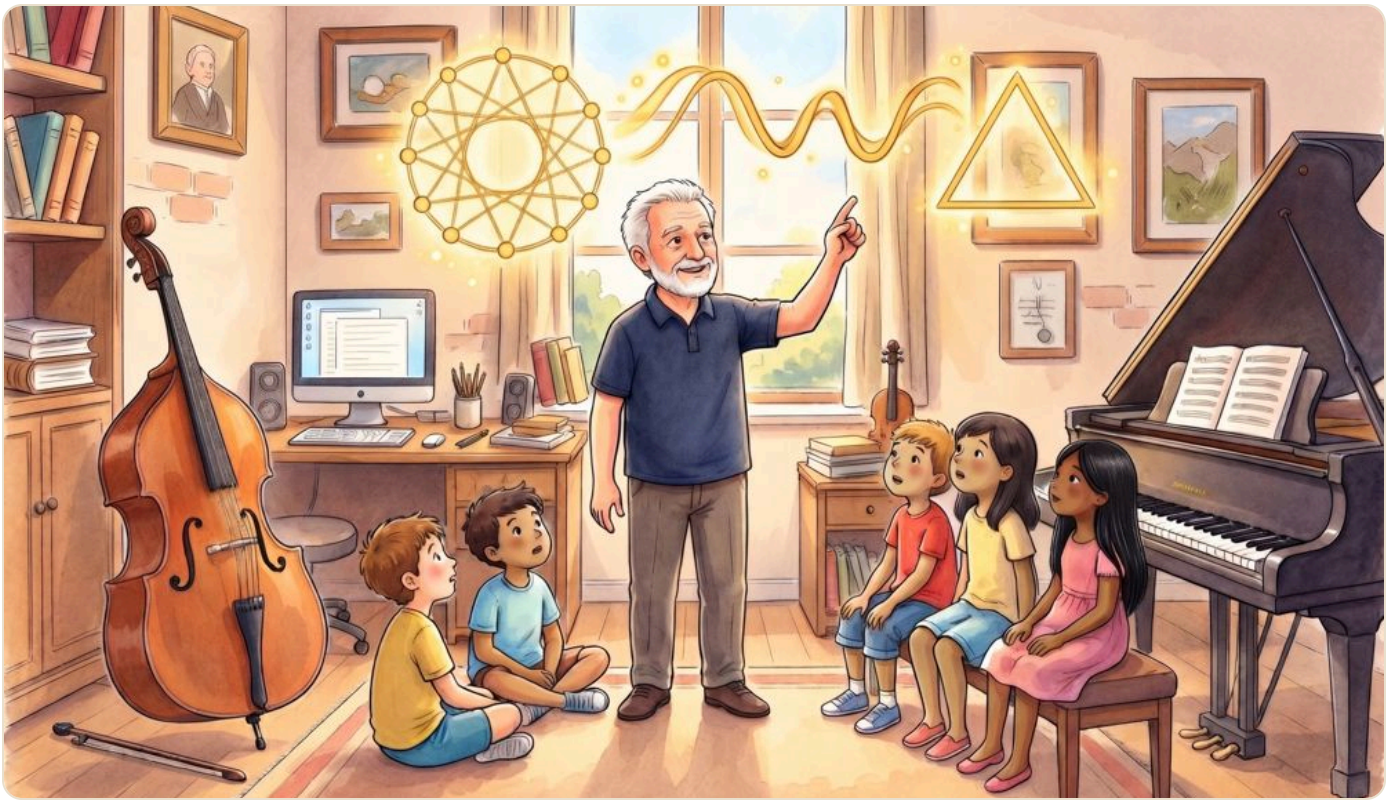
At home

- **The number dance**: one of you says '2', '3' or '4'; the other walks along counting and stamps hard on every 'one'.
- **Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star**: sing it together, with a clap on one and little taps on your knees on two, three and four.

CHAPTER 8

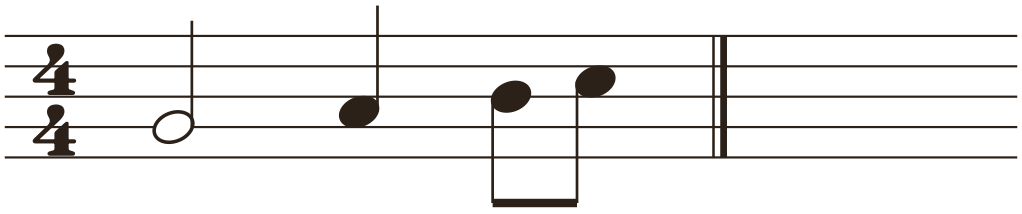
The numbers of music

The bar of chocolate, the sum in every bar and the beats we count



Without noticing, you have already done some maths: you broke the bar of chocolate into halves, quarters and eighths, and you grouped the beats in 2s, 3s and 4s. Music is full of numbers: **note values are fractions**, a **bar is a sum** and the **tempo is a number**. A bar of chocolate and a bar of music: both are split into equal pieces!

A 4/4 bar holds 4 beats, and you can fill it in lots of different ways. The only thing that matters is that it adds up to **4**:



2 **+ 1** **+ ½ + ½** **= 4**



CANELO SAYS

I count too: I have four legs, and every 4/4 bar has four beats. One, two, three, four… and again!

The number in the tempo marking tells you how many beats there are in a minute. At **60**: one beat every second, like the second hand of a clock. At **120**: two every second. The song lasts half as long, but it has just as many beats.

Let's play!

1. Finish the sums so that every bar makes 4:

   2 + 1 + ____ = 4 1 + ½ + ½ + ____ = 4 ____ + 2 = 4

2. 'Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star' has 12 bars of 4 beats. How many beats does the whole song have?
   12 × 4 = _____

3. How many different ways can you find to fill a bar of 4 with crotchets, minims and quavers? Draw them:



Did you know...? More than two hundred years ago, a game for composing waltzes by throwing two dice was published under Mozart's name. With numbers you could make millions of different waltzes! You will play it in Level 2.

At home

- **The second hand**: watch the second hand of a clock together and clap one beat every second: that is 60. Then twice as fast: 120.

CHAPTER 9

Our tune

Composing, writing the words and performing

Now it is your turn to write your own music. A tune is like a **journey**: it leaves home, wanders about and comes back. In C major, **C** is home, the home note. If the tune ends on C, with a long note, your ear feels it has arrived. If it ends on another note, it seems to hang in the air.

The tune machine gives you the first four bars. You write one of the missing bars, with the notes from C to G, and together you all add the words: **verses**.

A very old nursery rhyme, **'Hey Diddle Diddle'**, tells of the silliest things: a cat playing the fiddle, a cow jumping over the moon, a little dog laughing, a dish running away with the spoon... Every line is a new scene. This is how it goes:

Hey diddle diddle, the cat and the fiddle,
the cow jumped over the moon;
the little dog laughed to see such sport,
and the dish ran away with the spoon.



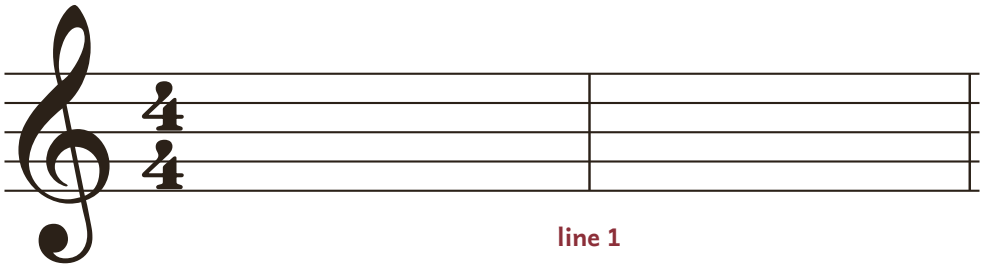


Edward Lear *(London, 1812–1888) wrote poems that sound like music, such as 'The Owl and the Pussy-cat': 'The Owl and the Pussy-cat went to sea / In a beautiful pea-green boat'. The Owl even sings to a small guitar by the light of the moon. Words have rhythm and melody too!*

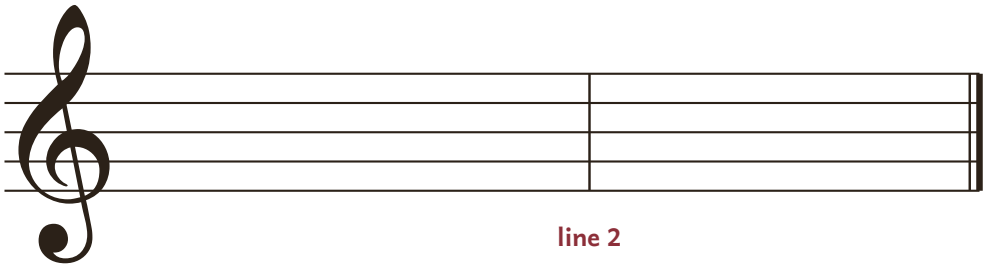
In 'Hey Diddle Diddle' each new silly scene can begin like this: ***'Hey diddle diddle, the ... and the ...'***
What silly scene will you make up? Edward Lear's whole poem, as it was printed in 1871:
en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Owl_and_the_Pussy-cat

Let's play!

1. Write **four bars** with notes from C to G; each bar has 4 beats. Every two bars hold one line of your verse.



line 1



line 2

2. Add the words. Look for words that fit the rhythm: the name of someone at home, something to eat, your pet.

3. Write your verse of four lines here:



CANELO SAYS

Composing isn't scary: it is choosing and putting together, like doing a jigsaw puzzle. And nobody has ever sung your song before!

At home

- **Four family bars**: together, write four bars, each one on a strip of paper with five lines. Play them in different orders. Which one ends 'at home'?

Our concert

Level 1 ends with music, and the families are invited



Each group presents its music and first says in one sentence what it is about. You choose one of these three forms:

- **The group's song**: the four bars from the tune machine and the four you wrote yourselves, with your words.
- **Verses**: four lines about your world: what you like, what worries you or what makes you laugh. Above all, the second and fourth lines rhyme.
- **A song from another time, in your own style**: a well-known tune, such as the 'Ode to Joy', as rock, rap, reggae or whatever is sung where you live.

Before the concert you **rehearse**: sing and play your song a few times, slowly at first and then up to speed. Agree on who starts, how you come in and how you all finish together.



CANELO SAYS

We can laugh at things and at ourselves, but never at a classmate. And at the end, we all clap for everyone!

The group sheet

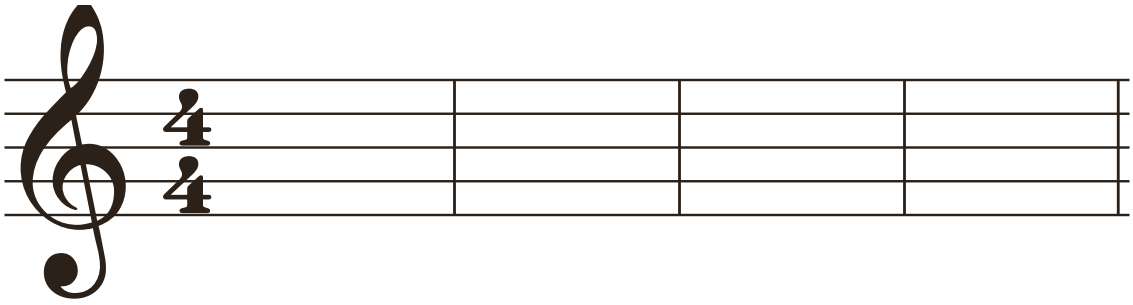
Name of the group: _____

Title of the song: _____

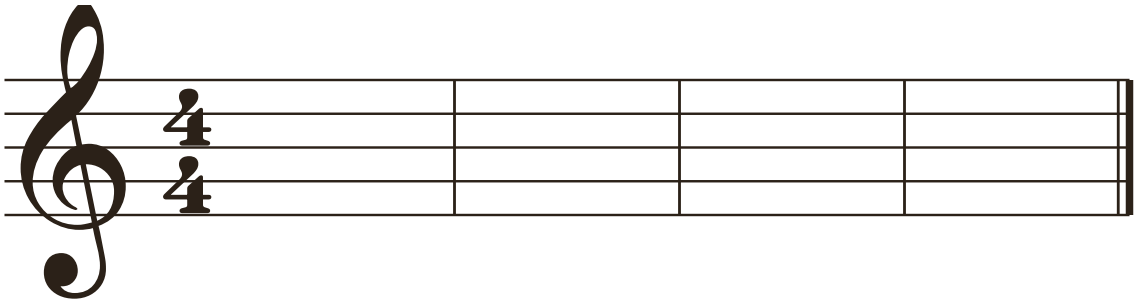
Our song is about: _____

We choose: ☐ the group's song ☐ verses ☐ a song from another time

Our tune. Bars 1 to 4, from the machine:



Bars 5 to 8, our own (the last one ends on C, with a long note):



Our words:

_____

_____

_____

_____

At the concert

Singing: _____

Playing an instrument (if someone brings one): _____

Introducing the song: _____

Costumes and props: _____

The teacher plays the recording of the song on the laptop.

Music words

A little dictionary to look back over the whole workbook

Beat
The heartbeat of music. Always evenly spaced, like the tick-tock of a clock.

Note
A sound with a name: C, D, E, F, G, A, B.

High and low
High is thin, like a bird. Low is deep, like thunder.

The singing staircase
The notes in a row, from the lowest to the highest.

Third
Skip one step: C–E, D–F, E–G.

Fifth
From C to G: the friendly note. Two thirds of the string give it.

Octave
The same note, but higher. Half the string gives it.

Stave
The house of the notes: five lines and four spaces.

Line and space
Where each note lives: with a line through it, or between two lines.

Treble clef
The key to the house: it gives line 2 the name G.

Note value
The shape of the note. It tells you how long the note lasts.

Semibreve, minim and crotchet
4, 2 and 1 beat: the whole bar of chocolate, half of it and a quarter.

Quaver
Half a beat. Two quavers are said ‘ti-ti’.

Rest
The time when the music is silent. The beat keeps counting.

Bar
A group of beats between two bar lines. The first one is the strong beat.

Time signature
The two numbers: on top, how many beats; underneath, which note value is the beat.

Tempo
How fast the beat goes. At 60: one beat every second.

Melody
A journey of notes: leaving home, wandering about and coming back.

Verse
Four lines to sing.



I can read and write music!

My Little Music Grammar · Level 1

This diploma is for
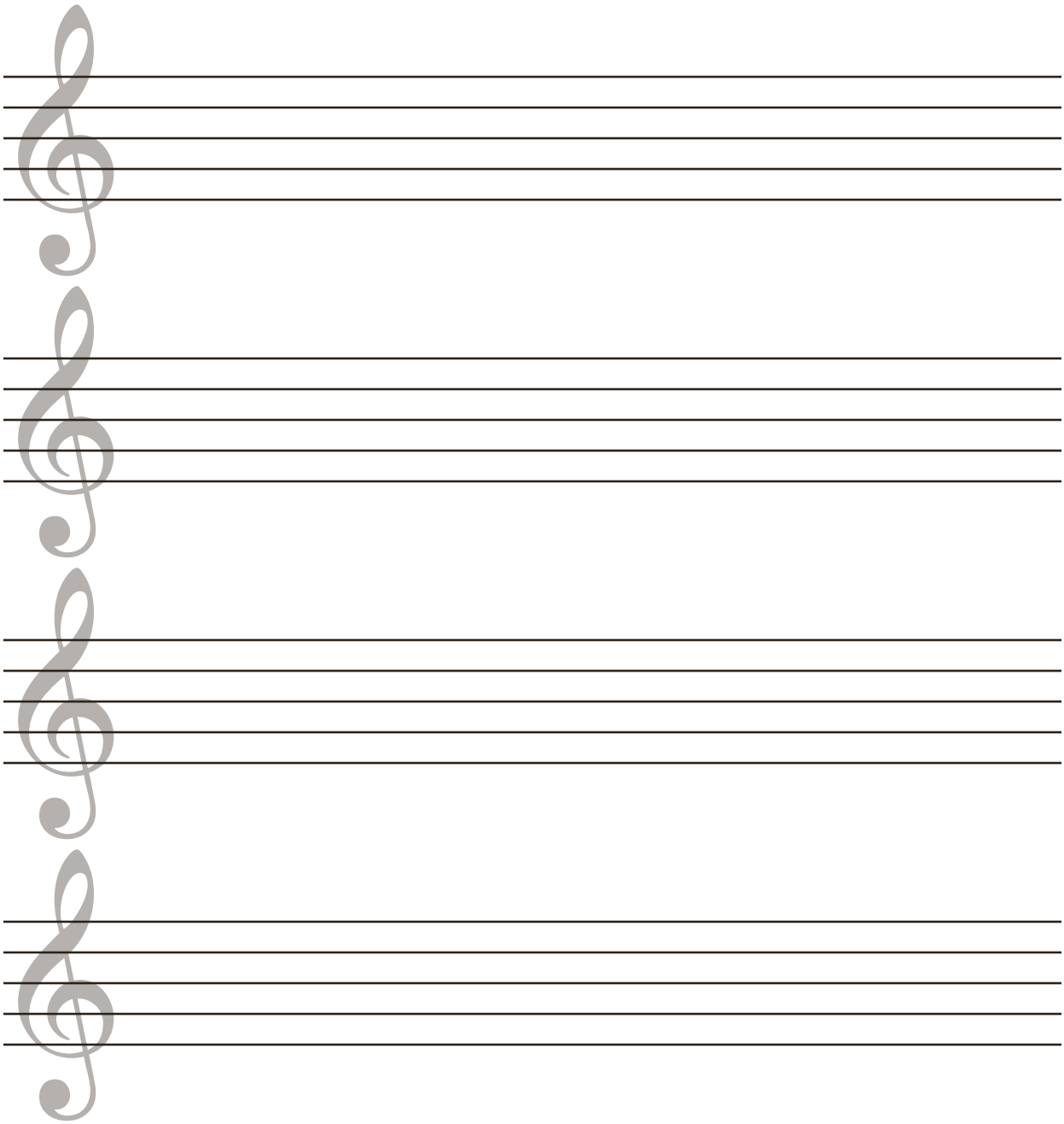
_____

who knows the beat, the singing staircase, the five-storey house, the treble clef,
the note values and their rests, the bar and its numbers,
and has composed a tune of their own.

_____ _____

The teacher Date

My music paper

For writing down your tunes, your rhythms and your verses



SOURCES

- Mario Maurano, *When Sound Becomes Music*. Music Motion.
- Wikipedia, the free encyclopedia (en.wikipedia.org): Pythagoras, the Seikilos epitaph, Mozart, the instruments of ancient peoples and the history of music writing.
- Edward Lear, *The Owl and the Pussy-cat* (1871), on Wikisource (en.wikisource.org).
- IMSLP · Petrucci Music Library (imslp.org): public-domain scores.